

DEDAN MSAFARI

Staff / Lead Product Manager · Technical & AI Product · Engineer-turned-Product Leader

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Open to: Remote (Global / US / EU / EMEA) · Hybrid · Nairobi · Available EU/US business hours

SUMMARY

Engineer-turned-product leader and founder. I spent years as a **lead mobile engineer (React Native)** shipping products end-to-end, then moved into **technical and AI-driven product management** for B2B SaaS. I'm the rare PM who owns strategy, roadmap, and delivery and architects systems and ships production code. Founder of **Soki**, a live multi-tenant SaaS platform (mobile + dashboard + web on one backend) whose monetization core is a shipped **AI product suite** (RAG document chat, revenue intelligence, auto-segmenting CRM, peer benchmarking, AI campaigns). Experienced leading distributed teams and serving US/EU clients fully remotely.

CORE SKILLS

Product & Leadership: Product Strategy · Roadmapping · Discovery & Validation · Backlog & Sprint Ownership · Agile/Scrum · Jira & Confluence · Stakeholder Management · Cross-functional & Distributed-team Leadership · OKRs

Engineering (hands-on): React Native / Expo · React · Next.js · Node.js · Firebase (RTDB, Cloud Functions) · REST APIs · Ruby on Rails · SQL · CI/CD · mobile architecture · code review & PR approval

AI Product: AI-assisted development (Claude Code, Cursor, ChatGPT) · LLM-augmented workflows · AI tooling strategy & team enablement · prompt engineering · LLM/AI search optimization (LLMO)

Growth & Design: Technical SEO · Search Atlas · on-page & backlink strategy · web analytics & reporting · Framer · Figma · UX/UI · conversion optimization

EXPERIENCE

Founder & CEO — Soki

2023 – Present

Soki (soki.co.ke) · Engagement OS for real-world venues · Nairobi / Remote

- Founder and product/engineering lead of a live, multi-tenant B2B SaaS platform. **Three apps on one backend:** a React Native mobile app (guests), a Next.js owner dashboard, and an SSR public web app, serving venues, apartments, campuses, and events.
- Designed and shipped an **AI product suite** as the monetization core: a document-chat assistant (RAG over PDFs/CSVs), revenue intelligence, an auto-segmenting community CRM, peer benchmarking, and AI-assisted campaigns, across tiered GPT-4o-mini/GPT-4o models with per-tier usage governance.
- Defined the full product strategy: a free QR/acquisition wedge converting to paid AI tiers, a four-step upgrade funnel, and a loss-aversion activation system, all specified in PRD-driven product docs cross-walked against shipping code.
- Architected and operate the production stack on **Firebase** (Firestore, RTDB, Cloud Functions, Storage): a multi-tenant security/projection boundary, a Cloud-Function write-gateway with a 5-layer anti-abuse stack (Turnstile, rate-limiting, profanity + Vision moderation), and edge-cached SSR tuned across regions (cut warm TTFB ~830ms → ~210ms).
- Led a major mobile platform migration (Expo SDK 51 to 54, React Native 0.74 to 0.81) end-to-end: dependency strategy, regression triage, and a staged production rollout.

Senior Technical Product Manager (Contract) — B2B SaaS (US client)

Jul 2025 – Present

Via talent partner · 100% Remote (US-based customer) · USDA-organic certification SaaS

- Own technical product management end-to-end for a B2B SaaS platform: translating business needs from the Product Owner into specs, defining acceptance criteria, and managing the full **Jira delivery pipeline** (backlog, sprint planning, stand-ups, releases).
- Took sole ownership of the company's **SEO function** using Search Atlas: running technical SEO, on-page optimization, backlink coordination, and rank tracking, with regular performance reporting to leadership. Drove early organic-traffic growth from a low baseline.
- Lead **AI adoption and direction** across product and engineering, introducing AI-assisted development workflows (Claude, Cursor, ChatGPT) and enabling the team to ship faster.

- Contribute **hands-on engineering**: scoping, building, and closing a class of tickets myself, and reviewing/approving PRs, compressing the product-to-production loop by removing hand-offs between PM, dev, and QA.
- Authored structured epics and stories (e.g. an annual-renewal workflow), drove tool evaluations (Search Atlas vs. Semrush), and maintained the marketing site in Framer ahead of a coded rebuild.

Lead Mobile Engineer (Freelance) — Celestify (UK) & Bridge Labs (US)

2024 – 2025

Independent · 100% Remote (UK & US clients, multiple time zones)

- Led mobile development (React Native) for two international consultancies, owning the full mobile lifecycle (architecture, build, and release) for their enterprise clients' apps.
- Drove product decisions around mobile features and UX, working directly with clients across UK and US time zones on an async-first basis.
- Contributed to delivery improvements including CI/CD and API integration work that streamlined release and integration cycles.

Lead Mobile Engineer — YoguPay (formerly Tumapay)

Feb 2023 – May 2024

Pan-African fintech · Nairobi, Kenya (Hybrid) · distributed team across Kenya, Nigeria, Ghana

- Led mobile engineering (React Native) for a Pan-African fintech platform processing high transaction volumes across multiple countries, owning mobile architecture, development, and app design end-to-end.
- Drove a mobile-first product direction that grew active users substantially, and optimized the mobile/API architecture to materially reduce data usage.
- Made product decisions on mobile features and UX in close partnership with the team, and improved release quality through automated testing and feature-flagged, low-downtime deployments.
- Supported launches into new markets and worked within a compliance framework spanning multiple regulatory regimes; this role began my transition from engineering into product.

Product Designer & UX Lead — Touch Inspiration

Jun 2021 – Aug 2022

Product/design agency · Nairobi, Kenya

- Led product and UX for 20+ enterprise client projects; built a reusable component and design system in Figma that cut feature-development time and enabled remote collaboration.
- Helped pivot the agency toward a retainer model, contributing to a significant revenue increase, and mentored junior designers.

Software Engineer (Intern) — Ongair

Jul 2019 – Mar 2020

Nairobi, Kenya

- Built full-stack features (React.js, Ruby on Rails) and REST APIs for a customer-communications platform; optimized database queries to significantly reduce page-load time and added an automated test suite.

EDUCATION

B.S., Computer Science · Egerton University, Nakuru, Kenya · 2020

ADDITIONAL

Engineering background: mobile & full-stack developer (React Native, Expo, Next.js, Firebase): the foundation of a hands-on, technical PM style.

Interests: building side projects, public speaking, mentoring early-stage founders and PMs in the African tech ecosystem.

References: available on request.